



A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

Kik is a messaging app that allows users to chat using usernames rather than phone numbers. While Kik is now intended for adults aged 18+, parents may still encounter references to it because it was historically popular with teenagers. Understanding how it works helps families discuss online safety confidently.



18+

Minimum age for new accounts



UK AGE CHECKS

Age verification required for UK users



USERNAME-BASED

Users do not need to share a phone number



GROUP CHATS

Can include people you do not know

Sources: Kik Safety Centre, UK Online Safety compliance requirements

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1



Messages aren't limited to friends

Users can receive messages from people they have never met.

2



Usernames can create a false sense of privacy

Not sharing a phone number does not remove all risks.

3



Most chats are harmless

The biggest concern is unwanted contact from strangers.

SAFETY FEATURES / SETTINGS

WHAT EXISTS



Block & Report

Block unwanted users and report concerns.



Chat Controls

Manage conversations and contacts.



Privacy Options

Limit unwanted interactions.



Group Management

Leave or manage group chats.

WHAT TO CHANGE



Review privacy settings together



Block unknown contacts immediately



Check group memberships regularly



Avoid usernames containing personal information

STEP-BY-STEP: USE KIK SAFELY

1



Review privacy settings together.

2



Use a username that reveals as little as possible.

3



Only chat with people you know offline.

4



Leave groups that feel uncomfortable.

5



Block and report unwanted messages.

6



Talk openly about online experiences.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING



Strangers Making Contact

Some users actively seek conversations with young people.



Inappropriate Messages

Unwanted content can sometimes appear.



Fake Profiles

Not everyone online is who they claim to be.



Age Misrepresentation

Some users may not be the age they claim.



Oversharing

Personal information can spread quickly.



Scams

Fraudulent links and requests do occur.



THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION



- ? What do you enjoy most about using Kik?
- ? Who do you usually chat with?
- ? How do you decide who to add?
- ? What would you do if a stranger messaged you?
- ? Do you know how to block someone?



TRUST OVER SURVEILLANCE

Open conversations build confidence. Children are more likely to ask for help when they know they won't get into trouble.

IF THINGS GO WRONG



STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE

- Save screenshots.
- Record usernames.
- Stop replying if a conversation feels unsafe.



REPORT & SEEK HELP

- Use Kik's reporting tools.
- Block the user immediately.
- Speak to a trusted adult.
- Contact police if there is immediate risk.



NEED TO TALK?
CHILDLINE



0800 1111
childline.org.uk



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